Northern Ireland. Lack of experience never stopped anyone dreaming, though. Once I'd established myself as an England player, I'd started to have ambitions—which, of course, I kept to myself—to make the next step, which would be the greatest honor of all. I've always believed that you should set yourself the highest of goals. I got as far as having a meeting with Kevin Keegan after Alan Shearer announced his international retirement. I wanted the England manager to know that I believed I could take on the job as captain. Kevin didn't say yes or no. But he did say he thought I would make an England captain one day.

By the time Kevin had left the international set-up, I think people were starting to talk about the possibility of me being up to the job. I have to say there were at least as many people against the idea at the time as were for it. And obviously it wasn't something I could make happen myself: I just had to wait and see, along with everybody else. The night before Peter Taylor announced his squad for the friendly game against Italy, Victoria was away and I was staying at Gary Neville's house. My cell phone rang at about eight o'clock in the morning. I'm not the best at getting up early, so my first, blurry reaction was: *Who the hell's that?*

I picked up the phone and managed to mutter:

'Hello?'

The voice at the other end was wide awake.

'Hello, David. It's Peter Taylor.'

I came to my senses very quickly indeed. I was out of bed and on my feet.

'Oh. Hello, Peter. How are you?'

The caretaker manager hadn't just rung up for a chat. I'll never forget what came next:

'Sorry to ring this early but I'm about to announce the squad. I've picked a young group and some new young players. I think the right thing is for you to captain them. I've got absolutely no doubt about you being ready for the job. I wanted you to know before I tell anybody else.'

I had to sit down again for five minutes. It crossed my mind that I might still be asleep. Had that phone call really happened? I was frozen to the spot by what I'd just heard: so excited, so proud, humbled by the thought of it. I